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RIISING FROM THE ASHES

Retooled Netscape Back In The Browser Game

Netscape, the Web browser out-muscled a decade ago by Microsoft's Internet Explorer, has undergone an extreme makeover in an attempt to regain its former relevance.

America Online, its current owner, released a trial version of Netscape 8.0 recently (browser.netscape.com), which packs some powerful security features, but falls short on speed and ease of use.

Among the useful aspects of this test release of Netscape 8.0 are tools for assessing the trustworthiness of Web sites and managing passwords. You can, for example, set a 'super' password granting one-word access to various Web sites; your many

different passwords can be stored one time, managed or changed easily, and secured from others who might use your computer.

The new Netscape is based largely on the open-source code for the increasingly popular Firefox browser, though Netscape has a different design and several functions that Firefox doesn't. Like Firefox, Netscape 8.0 supports tabbed browsing; unlike Firefox, Netscape has an elaborate new system for adjusting security settings. It stores a 'blacklist' of Web sites known to be dangerous on the user's computer and a list of sites thought to be trustworthy and updates those lists regularly. The browser displays a small red check mark—and a large security warning—when a user visits a site on the blacklist or if it detects other security issues at a site a user tries to call up.

Another difference is that Netscape has added Internet Explorer's page-rendering software under the hood, as an alternative viewing option. Since some sites are written to display

in only IE (or aren't tested to see how they look in other browsers), this gives users the option of viewing a site with the predominant browser if it looks bad or hangs up with Netscape.

Speaking of hanging up, Netscape's new browser crashed twice during a recent four-hour test. Worse, it was painfully slow, taking much longer than Internet Explorer or Firefox to render streamlined sites such as Google News.

MMS ATTACK

MMS Virus Discovered

The first mobile phone virus capable of replicating via MMS messages has been discovered. Commwarrior-A, which targets Symbian Series 60 phones, is not spreading, but its ability to propagate via Multimedia Messaging Service messages (MMS) worries some experts.

To date, phone viruses have spread over Bluetooth—so they were only capable of

affecting nearby phones. An MMS virus could potentially spread as quickly as an email worm. Finnish anti-virus firm F-Secure thinks the virus may be from Russia because it contains text that says "OTMOP03KAM HET!". Which roughly translates to "No to braindeads!"

CRIPPLEWARE OVERDUE

Windows XP Starter Edition In June

A Microsoft India official said that the company would launch Windows XP Starter Edition, the stripped-down version of XP, with local language capabilities in India by June. It was initially slated to be released in March. "It is a little delayed and the engineers are still sorting out local language features," Microsoft India director (business and marketing operations) Ranjivit Singh told